

Islamicate Occult Sciences in Theory and Practice

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Toward a Neopythagorean Historiography: Kemālpaşazāde's (d. 1534) Lettrist Call for the Conquest of Cairo and the Development of Ottoman Occult-Scientific Imperialism

Matthew Melvin-Koushki

The occult sciences, recent research has shown, were central to the construction of Ottoman imperial ideology and political-military strategy from the late ninth/fifteenth century until the mid-tenth/sixteenth, and their prestige persisted long thereafter.¹ Bāyezīd II (r. 886–918/1481–1512) initiated this turn with his devotion to astrology; he institutionalized the science at the Ottoman court to an extent unprecedented and perhaps unparalleled elsewhere in the early modern West.² But it is only with the astonishing conquests of his son Yavuz Selīm (r. 918–926/1512–1520)—seemingly magical in their rapidity—that we

- 1 See, in particular, Cornell Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom and New Sciences: Prophecies at the Ottoman Court in the Fifteenth and Early Sixteenth Centuries," in *Falnama: Book of Omens*, ed. Massoumeh Farhad and Serpil Bağcı (London: Thames & Hudson, 2009): 232–243; Cornell Fleischer, "Shadow of Shadows: Prophecy in Politics in 1530s Istanbul," in *Identity and Identity Formation in the Ottoman World: A Volume of Essays in Honor of Norman Itzkowitz*, ed. Baki Tezcan and Karl K. Barbir (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 2007), 51–62. On the persistence of a prototypically Timurid (and, by extension, Ottoman) mode of imperial occultism in the Persianate world even through the turn of the twentieth century, see Matthew Melvin-Koushki and James Pickett, "Mobilizing Magic: Occultism in Central Asia and the Continuity of High Persianate Culture under Russian Rule," *Studia Islamica* 111, no. 2 (2016): 231–284.
- 2 See Ahmet Tunç Şen, "Astrology in the Service of the Empire: Knowledge, Prognostication, and Politics at the Ottoman Court" (PhD diss., University of Chicago, 2016); Ahmet Tunç Şen, "Reading the Stars at the Ottoman Court: Bāyezīd II (r. 886/1481–918/1512) and His Celestial Interests," in "Islamicate Occultism: New Perspectives," ed. Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Noah Gardiner, special double issue of *Arabica* 64, nos. 3–4 (2017): 557–608. For intellectual and cultural-historical purposes, I define "the West" as the half of Afro-Eurasia west of South India, incorporating the Arabic, Persian, and Latin cosmopolises, that vast realm where the Hellenic-Abrahamic synthesis reigned supreme and philosophy was pursued in simultaneously mathematical and linguistic terms (Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Taḥqīq vs. Taqlīd in the Renaissances of Western Early Modernity," *Philological Encounters* 3, no. 1 (2018): 193–249). To the extent other regions were later incorporated into these cosmopolises, moreover, they too may be considered Western.

can begin to speak of an Ottoman Empire, and the beginnings of *Ottoman imperial universalism*. Like his father Bāyezīd and more glorious son Kānūnī Süleymān (r. 926–974/1520–1566), Selīm would seem to have been an important patron of the occult sciences to this end. Yet he has been little studied as such. Nevertheless, surviving archival evidence suggests that Selīm too relied on court occultists (astrologers, lettrists, geomancers) for political and military intelligence during his career of conquest and took seriously their ideological formulations in panegyric; this includes in the first place his campaigns against the Safavids at the Battle of Chaldiran in 920/1514 and against the Mamluk Sultanate in 922/1516–1517. With his conclusive, epochal triumphs, which vaulted the Ottoman state to the status of an Islamicate and Mediterranean superpower, Ottoman imperial ideology became increasingly aggressively millenarian and apocalyptic in tenor—as well as *occult-scientific*.

Due to endemic scholarly occultophobia, however, this basic feature of early Ottoman imperialism has long been elided in the historiography, apart from the work of a few specialists in the last two decades; as a consequence, most of the great mass of relevant occult-scientific texts produced by Ottoman court elites have yet to be studied, much less published in modern editions. This is a problem that continues to cripple the study of Islamicate and especially Persianate early modernity as a whole: the intellectual and social history of Arabo-Persian occult sciences like astrology, alchemy, lettrism, and geomancy—utterly mainstream in the elite scholarly discourses of the post-Mongol Persian cosmopolis, including the Ottoman sphere—remains almost entirely unwritten. Not one monograph on any of these major components and drivers of Western early modernity has been published to date.³ This, of course, is in extreme contrast to scholarship on the early modern Far West, which is to say Latinate Europe, where the same sciences, particularly astrology and kabbalah, have been taken incomparably more seriously by historians of science and historians of empire

3 While several such studies are forthcoming, at the time of writing they remain primarily in the form of unpublished dissertations produced in the last seven years. See, e.g., Şen, “Astrology in the Service”; Tuna Artun, “Hearts of Gold and Silver: Production of Alchemical Knowledge in the Early Modern Ottoman World” (PhD diss., Princeton University, 2013); Nicholas G. Harris, “Better Religion through Chemistry: Aydemir al-Jildakī and Alchemy under the Mamluks” (PhD diss., University of Pennsylvania, 2020); Noah D. Gardiner, “Esotericism in a Manuscript Culture: Aḥmad al-Būnī and His Readers through the Mamlūk Period” (PhD diss., University of Michigan, 2014); Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest for a Universal Science: The Occult Philosophy of Šāʾin al-Dīn Turka Işfahānī (1369–1432) and Intellectual Millenarianism in Early Timurid Iran” (PhD diss., Yale University, 2012); Fien De Block, “(Re)drawing the Lines: The Science of the Stars in the Late Fifteenth Century Sultanate of Cairo” (PhD diss., Ghent University, 2020).

alike—for occult science becomes a reasonable pursuit worthy of chronicling only when done by Latin Christians. Multiple studies apiece have thus been devoted to or frequently treat of early modern Christian sovereigns, like Rudolf II (r. 1576–1612), Holy Roman Emperor, and Peter the Great (r. 1682–1725), Europeanizer of Russia, precisely in their status as *occult philosopher-kings*,⁴ but none to Selim's equally openly occult-scientific construction of the Ottoman Empire as New Byzantium. Indeed, the first scholarly monograph on Selim in a West European language was published only in 2017, and it nowhere notes the Ottoman conqueror's personal reliance on occult scientists for both ideological and military-strategic purposes.⁵

Such a blatant double standard, purely Enlightened colonialist-orientalist in origin, is designed to mystify, to Otherize, to *de-Westernize* the Mediterranean empire that is the Ottoman, to say nothing of its competitor Persianate imperial polities to the east.⁶ That our picture of Ottoman occult-scientific imperial culture is necessarily still hazy and impressionistic as a result further reinforces in turn the historiographically perverting impression, *entirely illusory*, of a strict early modern East-West, Islamdom-Christendom divide. While this impression is being ably combated on many fronts, particularly by historians committed to Sanjay Subrahmanyam's connected histories approach to the study of the millenarian imperialism common to the early modern Afro-Eurasian ecumene as a whole,⁷ the *occult science* front remains firmly in the control of hostile historiographical forces dedicated to the mystification and orientalizing of Islam.

But the remedy is a simple one, if strenuous: let us to the Arabo-Perso-Turkish sources.⁸ This article is a modest offering in this philological vein.

4 See, e.g., Peter Marshall, *The Magic Circle of Rudolf II: Alchemy and Astrology in Renaissance Prague* (New York: Walker, 2009); Robert Collis, *The Petrine Instauration: Religion, Esotericism and Science at the Court of Peter the Great, 1689–1725* (Leiden: Brill, 2012). This spate of scholarship was initiated by Frances Yates (d. 1981), particularly in her *Astraea: The Imperial Theme in the Sixteenth Century* (London: Pimlico, 1975).

5 H. Erdem Çipa, *The Making of Selim: Succession, Legitimacy, and Memory in the Early Modern Ottoman World* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2017). This otherwise excellent study, which rightly presents Selim as quintessential early modern Eurasian ruler, touches in passing on only a few of the occult-scientific aspects (astrological, letrist, oneiromantic) of the various ideological (re)constructions of Selim's royal persona after his death.

6 On this problem, see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "(De)colonizing Early Modern Occult Philosophy," *Magic, Ritual, and Witchcraft* 12, no. 1 (2017): 98–112.

7 An approach first announced in Subrahmanyam, "Connected Histories: Notes towards a Reconfiguration of Early Modern Eurasia," *Modern Asian Studies* 31, no. 3 (1997): 735–762; see also Cornell Fleischer, "A Mediterranean Apocalypse: Prophecies of Empire in the Fifteenth and Sixteenth Centuries," *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 61 (2018): 18–90.

8 See my call for a return to *radical cosmic philology* in Melvin-Koushki, "Tahqīq vs. Taqlīd."

Given how thickly occult-scientific texts populate the surviving Ottoman archive, however, we are fairly spoiled for choice. I therefore invoke as representative example a short Turkish treatise ostensibly penned by Kemālpaşazāde Aḥmed (d. 940/1534) in late 1516 or early 1517, wherein the famed Ottoman scholar and soon-to-be imperial Chief Jurisconsult (*shaykh al-Islām*) urges Selim to conquer Cairo—a feat his dread patron promptly achieved (in February 1517), with major ramifications for early modern Western history. Indeed, later sources suggest that it was precisely his ideological support for Selim during the Ottoman invasion of the Mamluk Sultanate, in which he participated, that earned our scholar his exalted imperial appointment in Istanbul several years later.⁹ Significantly, however, Kemālpaşazāde's argument therein is exclusively *lettrist*: he analyzes Q 21:105—*For We have written in the Psalms, after the Remembrance: My righteous servants shall inherit the land*—to scientifically prove the Ottoman sovereign's conquest of the Mamluk capital to be *cosmically inevitable*.

Despite the fame of its author, this curious yet likely authentic little work, titled simply *Feth-i Mısır hakkında imā ve işārāt* ("Allusions as to the Conquest of Egypt") and preserved in at least two late manuscripts,¹⁰ has been ignored in the scholarship to date. The sole exception is a brief 1990 study with modern Latin transcription by Mustafa Kılıç, which first brought it to light; but that study, symptomatically, wholly abstracts the treatise from its intellectual and ideological context.¹¹ (Cornell Fleischer's brief citation of the same treatise provides a corrective.¹²) True, it is easily disappeared into Kemālpaşazāde's vast

9 Kemālpaşazāde likewise provided crucial legal support for Selim's offensive against the Safavids at the Battle of Chaldiran, penning to this end a treatise, *Risāla fi Takfīr al-rawāfiḍ* ("On declaring the rejectionists [i.e., Shi'is] unbelievers"), that rules war against Shah Ismā'il to be not a collective but an individual legal obligation (*fard 'ayn*) (V.L. Ménage, "Kemāl Pasha-Zāde," *Encyclopaedia of Islam*, 2nd ed.; see Nihal Atsız, "Kemalpaşaoğlu'nun Eserleri I," *Şarkiyat Mecmuası* 6 (1966): 71–112, esp. 109–110, no. 84). In recognition of his ideological support for this and the Syria campaign, Selim had already promoted him to the prestigious post of chief military judge (*kāḍī'asker*) of Anadolu in late 1516. It should be noted, however, that Kemālpaşazāde was not elevated to the position of *şeyḫülislam* until 1524, and demoted from his military judgeship in the meantime (my thanks to Ahmet Tunç Şen for this observation).

10 Istanbul, Süleymaniye MS Esad Efendi 3729/2, fols. 136^a–137^b; Konya, MS Mevlana Müzesi 2315/2, fols. 71^b–72^b. In the latter *majmū'a*, Kemālpaşazāde's treatise occurs between the poet Faḫrī's (d. 1563) *Gül u bülbül* ("Rose and nightingale") (fols. 2^b–70^a) and a collection of his own fatwas (fols. 73^a–99^b).

11 Mustafa Kılıç, "İbn-i Kemal'in Mısır Fethine Dair Bir Risale-i Acibesi," *Diyanet Dergisi* 26 (1990): 111–120.

12 Fleischer, "Seer to the Sultan: Haydar-i Remmal and Sultan Süleyman," in *Cultural Hori-*

oeuvre, the majority of which is not occult-scientific in tenor; yet it offers a window onto not just one Ottoman scholar's individual occultist "dabbings" but rather the development of Ottoman, and by extension early modern Islamicate, universalist imperial ideology as a whole, and that at a critical, transformative juncture in Western history.

I do not here propose to situate Kemālpaşazāde's treatise in the broader history of lettrism ('ilm al-ḥurūf), a science I have treated of elsewhere at length in relation to post-Mongol history of science and history of empire;¹³ I will merely adumbrate, as a prompt to specialists, the immediate textual and theoretical context in which it may most productively be read. Suffice it to say that in the early modern Persianate context lettrism emerged as the primary expression of Islamic *Neopythagoreanism*—precisely as kabbalah, the Arabic science's coeval Hebrew twin, was being embraced as the same by Jewish and Christian scholars in the Renaissance Latinate world as (Arabic/Hebrew) text.¹⁴ This study thus but provides further philological corroboration of the framework for the study of early modern Ottoman occult-scientific, millenarian, and apocalyptic imperialism constructed by Cornell Fleischer and İhsan Fazlıoğlu and their students.¹⁵ More specifically, it serves to complement Ahmet Tunç Şen's work on Ottoman astrology in general and Kemālpaşazāde in particular, to whom was also attributed, probably correctly, a treatise on talismans and astral magic, likewise calculated to serve Ottoman imperial ends,¹⁶ and our

zons: A Festschrift in Honor of Talat S. Halman, ed. Jayne L. Warner, 2 vols. (Istanbul and Syracuse: Syracuse University Press, 2001), 1:290–299, esp. 295.

- 13 See, e.g., Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Powers of One: The Mathematicalization of the Occult Sciences in the High Persianate Tradition," *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 5, no. 1 (2017): 127–199; Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Imperial Talismanic Love: Ibn Turka's *Debate of Feast and Fight* (1426) as Philosophical Romance and Lettrist Mirror for Timurid Princes," *Der Islam* 96, no. 1 (2019): 42–86; Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Early Modern Islamicate Empire: New Forms of Religiopolitical Legitimacy," in *The Wiley-Blackwell History of Islam*, ed. Armando Salvatore, Roberto Tottoli, and Babak Rahimi (Hoboken, NJ: Wiley-Blackwell, 2017), 353–375.
- 14 See, e.g., Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "The New Brethren of Purity: Ibn Turka and the Renaissance of Neopythagoreanism in Early Modern Iran," in *Companion to the Reception of Pythagoras and Pythagoreanism*, ed. Aurélien Robert, Irene Caiazzo, and Constantin Macris, 2 vols. (Leiden: Brill, forthcoming); Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "World as (Arabic) Text: Mīr Dāmād and the Neopythagoreanization of Philosophy in Safavid Iran," *Studia Islamica* 114, no. 3 (2019): 378–431.
- 15 See, e.g., Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom"; Fazlıoğlu, "İlk Dönem Osmanlı İlim ve Kültür Hayatında İhvan-ı Safâ ve Abdurrahman Bistâmî," *Dîvân: İlmî Araştırmalar* 1 (1996): 229–240.
- 16 This treatise is studied and contextualized in A. Tunç Şen, "Practicing Astral Magic in Sixteenth-Century Ottoman Istanbul: A Treatise on Talismans Attributed to Ibn Kemāl (d. 1534)," *Magic, Ritual, and Witchcraft* 12, no. 1 (2017): 66–88.

study of Selīm's reliance on astrology, lettrism, and geomancy in the runup to the Battle of Chaldiran and its immediate aftermath.¹⁷ It also extends Noah Gardiner's equally pivotal studies of thirteenth- to fifteenth-century Mamluk Cairo as emergent occult-scientific capital of the Islamicate world.¹⁸ To their findings I add my own on intellectual-ideological developments between Mamluk, Timurid, and Aqquyunlu spheres during the transformative ninth/fifteenth century—precisely the source, I argue, of Ottoman *lettrist* imperialism, first developed in the early tenth/sixteenth century in the immediate wake of Selīm's victory at Chaldiran and conquest of Syria and Egypt, of which Kemālpaşazāde is among the earliest exponents.¹⁹ More broadly, this study stands as counterpoint and control for the study of those cognate—if less successful—early modern forms of *Christian kabbalist* scientific imperialism developed slightly to the west, emblemized by the ardent Welsh Neopythagoreanizer John Dee's (d. 1609) status as occultist-cartographer to Queen Elizabeth I (r. 1558–1603) and coiner of the term "Brytish Impire."²⁰

1 Kemālpaşazāde's Lettrist Argument

The lettrist argument advanced by our Ottoman scholar-ideologue in this short treatise is admirably pellucid and straightforward, and easily summarized. For the text itself, I refer the reader to Kılıç's (highly idiosyncratic) transcription of that preserved in MS Mevlana Müzesi 2315, the work of a later copyist, who opens, in encomium: "That sultan of scholars and lord of worthies, the late Kemālpaşazāde, produced the following remarkable (*'acīb*) treatise on the conquest of Egypt."

17 Şen and Melvin-Koushki, "Divining Chaldiran: Ottoman Deployments of Astrology, Lettrism and Geomancy in the Ottoman-Safavid Conflict," forthcoming.

18 See, e.g., Gardiner, "Esotericism"; Gardiner, "The Occultist Encyclopedism of 'Abd al-Rahmān al-Bisṭāmī," *Mamlūk Studies Review* 20 (2017): 3–38, and his forthcoming monograph *Occult Cairo*.

19 I summarize my findings to date in two forthcoming monographs: *Occult Philosophers and Philosopher Kings in Early Modern Iran: The Life and Legacy of Ibn Turka, Timurid Lettrist*, and *The Occult Science of Empire in Aqquyunlu-Safavid Iran: Two Shirazi Lettrists and Their Manuals of Magic*.

20 See, e.g., John Dee, *The Limits of the British Empire*, ed. Ken MacMillan (Westport, CT: Praeger, 2004); Håkan Håkansson, *Seeing the Word: John Dee and Renaissance Occultism* (Lund: Lunds Universitet, 2001); Yates, *Astraea*. For a comparative study of early modern Western (Islam-Christianate) occult-scientific imperialisms, see Melvin-Koushki, *The Occult Science of Empire*.

Again, the treatise consists wholly of an analysis of Q 21:105: *For We have written in the Psalms, after the Remembrance: My righteous servants shall inherit the land.* Even on the face of it, this quranic promise has a clear imperialist thrust and had long been interpreted and invoked as such, but it is entirely vague as to historical timing: any self-identified Muslim sovereign was free to lay claim to it, and many did over the centuries. How best, then, to make one's imperial claim to a quranic promise *exclusive*, in the teeth of rival claimants?

By means of lettrist analysis, whereby the Quran itself may be mathematized, and hence rehistoricized. It is a basic principle of letter divination (*jafr*), from the Comprehensive Prognosticon (*al-Jafr wa-l-jāmi'a*) of 'Alī b. Abī Ṭālib (d. 40/661) onward, that the quranic *muqatta'āt*²¹ are the richest possible source of data about past, present, and future events, especially political events, to the end of time; but this principle could be and was easily extended to the Quran as a whole, and indeed to any word or name of relevance, such as those of the political actors involved.²² As with the famous Sūrat al-Rūm prophecy, on which more below, temporally vague quranic statements may thus be revealed to encode the precise dates on and places in which, and by precisely whose agency, they may be expected to historically manifest. A basic facility with lettrist operations, such as *ḥisāb al-jummal* and *taksīr* (cf. Hebrew *gematria* and *temurah*), could therefore be an especially attractive skill in a scholar in search of royal patronage. In penning this short treatise, then, Kemālpaşazāde showed himself to be one such scholar; and Selīm rewarded him more than amply for his mastery of this mathematical-quranic science.

Our soon-to-be Ottoman *şeyhülislam* boldly opens with a summary of his lettrist findings:

The cited holy verse constitutes a sublime and subtle allusion to the fact that the lands of Egypt will, in the wintertime of two years past 9[20], easily pass from the hands of the slave faction controlling the aforementioned region into the control of the governors of free men, who will eradicate them. That victorious army's leader will be of the house of 'Osmān and they hence are called Ottomans; and the glorious sultan who will lead them in the conquest of the aforesaid region will be called Selīm.

21 That is, the mysterious separated letters that open 29 quranic suras; the second, Sūrat al-Baqara, for instance, opens with *ALM*. They have no parallel in the other Abrahamic scriptures and immediately lend themselves to—even require, according to some exegetes—lettrist analysis.

22 See Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 171–172, 285–290.

The balance of the treatise consists of a series of ten points in which the following operative elements of the verse are identified and analyzed (here bolded):

﴿وَلَقَدْ كَتَبْنَا فِي الزَّبُورِ مِنْ بَعْدِ الذِّكْرِ أَنَّ الْأَرْضَ يَرِثُهَا عِبَادِيَ الصَّالِحُونَ﴾

wa-la-qad = 140 = *Salīm* *dhikr* = 920

al-zabūr = *zamharīr* *al-arḍ* = *miṣr*

B = 2 *‘ibādī* = [*Uthmān*] *bādī*

- 1) That this event will take place sometime after the Hijrī year 920 [1514–1515 CE] is indicated by the phrase *after the Remembrance* (*min ba’d al-dhikr*)—for *dhikr* equals 920.
- 2) That this event will take place two years after the Hijrī year 920, that is, in 922 [1516–1517 CE], is indicated by the preposition *ba’d*, here broken into its elements, *B* (= 2) and *‘ad*[*d*], together meaning “the count of two,” that is added to the 920 of *dhikr*.
- 3) That this event will take place in winter is indicated by the phrase *in the Psalms* (*fi l-zabūr*), for *fi* is likewise a temporal particle, while *al-zabūr* comprises seven letters (with the *L* doubled), the same value as its initial letter *Z*—which therefore governs the timing of this event. In this case, it refers to the term *zamharīr*, the bitter cold of winter, which is referred to in common usage as the “forty days” (*eyyām-i ‘erba’in*). It is thus apparent that the battle in question will occur toward the end of the forty days of winter.
- 4) That the site of this event will be Egypt is indicated by the fact that in the holy, uncreated Quran (*kelām-i ḡadīm*) the term *the land* (*al-arḍ*), when used with the definite particle, usually refers to Egypt, as the following ten verses show, all treating of the Israelites under Pharaoh and their exodus: *And We bequeathed upon the people that were abased in all the east and the west of the land We had blessed* (Q 7:137); *Yet We desired to be gracious to those that were abased in the land, and to make them leaders, and to make them the inheritors* (Q 28:5); *And to establish them in the land, and to show Pharaoh and Haman, and their hosts, what they were dreading from them* (Q 28:6); *O my people, enter the Holy Land which God has prescribed for you, and turn not back in your traces, to turn about losers* (Q 5:21); *Wilt thou leave Moses and his people to work corruption in the land ...?* (Q 7:127); *‘Set me over the land’s storehouses ...’* (Q 12:55); *So We established Joseph in the land* (Q 12:56); *Now Pharaoh had exalted himself*

in the land and had divided its inhabitants into sects (Q 28:4); *‘Never will I quit this land ...’* (Q 12:80); *‘Thou only desirest to be a tyrant in the land ...’* (Q 28:19).²³

- 5) The fifth indication as to the invasion (*khurūj*) will only become evident through an explanation of the eighth below.
- 6) That the conquest will happen easily and quickly is indicated by the verb *shall inherit* (*yarithu*), implying a lack of struggle and great wealth as spoils.
- 7) The verse likewise concerns the removal of the aforementioned realm from the control of the slaves (i.e., *mamlūks*), indicating that that faction and their heirs will be subjugated and perish where they stand, and this at the hand of free men, their natural masters—for God’s servants (as denoted by the pronoun *My*) are no slaves.²⁴
- 8) This has already been explained.²⁵
- 9) That the victorious army will be led by a scion of ‘Oṣmān is indicated by the word *My servants* (*‘ibādī*), which is parsable as ‘ + *BADY*, with the initial ‘ referring to ‘Oṣmān and the *BADY* here reading *bādī*, which is to say manifest (*zāhir*).
- 10) That the scion of ‘Oṣmān who will manifest to lead the victorious army in question must be Selīm is indicated by the intensifying particle cluster opening the verse, *wa-la-qad* (*WLQD*), equivalent to 140—the same value as the name *Selīm* (*SLYM*).

Thus analyzed, the verse is now revealed to read:

Selīm—We have decreed that two [years] after 920 [1514–1515], in the winter, this [son of] ‘Oṣmān shall manifest leading an army of righteous, free men and easily take Egypt.

And so it came to pass: In the winter of 922 (January–February 1517), upon Kemālpaşazāde’s lettrist prompting, Selīm did indeed manifest with his army and easily take Egypt. (As it happened, the decisive Battle of Raydāniyya was

23 Trans. Arberry. As Kılıç notes (“İbn-i Kemal’in,” 115 n. 3, 118–119), Kemālpaşazāde rather identifies this term with Syria in his tafsir.

24 On a similar Aqqyunlu critique of Mamluk slave origins see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “The Delicate Art of Aggression: Uzun Hasan’s *Fathnama* to Qaytbay of 1469,” *Iranian Studies* 44, no. 2 (2011): 193–214, esp. 196.

25 Point eight was not, in fact, explained in point five as promised, suggesting an error on the part of the copyist, or perhaps Kılıç, whose transcription is rather unreliable.

fought on 29 Dhū l-Ḥijja 922/23 January 1517, the last day of the Islamic lunar year—one day later, and Kemālpaşazāde's calculation as given in the treatise would have been invalidated.) Selīm's quranic claim, unlike his Muslim opponents', is therefore encoded mathematically in the very structure of the cosmos and hence historically ineluctable.²⁶

To be sure, the document recording Kemālpaşazāde's coup is brief and preserved, to my knowledge, in only two later copies and thus of questionable authenticity. Yet it accords with the scholar's known occult-scientific proclivities,²⁷ and the episode it records soon gained fame in scholarly circles as a classic instance of quranic prognostication in the support of empire; such factors suggest it to be at base authentic. But even if originally inauthentic, it is indicative of an early-tenth/sixteenth-century Ottoman ethos: within a century the same episode was circulating under his name even in Ottoman Arabia. It is cited, most notably, by the Maghribi Sufi-scholar and traveler Abū Sālim 'Abd Allāh al-'Ayyāshī (d. 1090/1679) in his celebrated *Rihla* ("Travelogue"), an exceptionally rich account of his sojourn in Cairo, Mecca, Medina, and Jerusalem between the years 1661–1663, whence it became a standard component of Kemālpaşazāde's biography.²⁸ Two centuries later, Shihāb al-Dīn Maḥmūd al-Alūsī (d. 1270/1854), Hanafi mufti of Baghdad, notes in his *tafsīr* on this verse Kemālpaşazāde's amazingly (*gharīb*) accurate prognostication for Selīm as being a well-known story (*qiṣṣa shahīra*), though he personally dismisses it as mere chance;²⁹ another century on, our Ottoman scholar's entry as a historically preeminent Hanafi jurist in the legal history *al-Fikr al-sāmī fī ta'rīkh al-fiqh al-islāmī* ("High Intellection: On the History of Islamic Jurisprudence") of Muḥammad al-Ḥajwī al-Tha'ālībī al-Fāsī (d. 1376/1956), reformist minister of justice in French-protectorate Morocco, consists solely of this episode in al-'Ayyāshī's telling.³⁰ Significantly for our purposes here, moreover, the latter occurs in the context of the traveling scholar's unusually long discussion of his interactions with one Shaykh Shihāb al-Dīn Aḥmad Ibn al-Tāj, chief timekeeper

26 And yet, had Selīm not been persuaded with legal and lettrist arguments, would he actually have invaded Egypt? On a similar instance of the tension between free will and predestination in Ottoman lettrist historiography, see Noah Gardiner's Chapter 6 in this volume.

27 See below.

28 Al-'Ayyāshī, *al-Rihla al-'Ayyāshiyya*, ed. Sa'īd al-Fāḍilī and Sulaymān al-Qurashī, 2 vols. (Abu Dhabi: Dār al-Suwaydī, 2006), 2:30–32.

29 Al-Alūsī, *Rūḥ al-ma'ānī fī tafsīr al-Qur'ān al-'aẓīm wa-l-sab' al-mathānī*, 30 vols. (Beirut: Dār Iḥyā' al-Turāth al-'Arabī, 1970?), 17:104.

30 Al-Ḥajwī, *Kitāb al-Fikr al-sāmī fī ta'rīkh al-fiqh al-islāmī*, 4 vols. (Rabat: Maṭba'at Idārat al-Ma'ārif, 1345–1349/1927–31), 4:23–24, no. 550. This and the previous two sources are cited by Kılıç.

(*muwaqqit*) at the sanctuary in Medina; like many of his profession, Ibn al-Tāj was renowned for his skill in the mathematical sciences, including in the first place astrology, lettrism and various other methods of prognostication—sciences evidently still esteemed by Ottoman political elites of the later eleventh/seventeenth century no less than by those of the early tenth/sixteenth.³¹ I translate it in full:

Another example of the same principle, to wit, that the holy Quran comprises within it information about everything [that has been, is or will ever be], including disasters and other major events, was related to me by my current subject, Shihāb al-Dīn Aḥmad Ibn al-Tāj, as follows:

The king of Anatolia (*malik bilād al-Rūm*), Sultan Salīm, one of the [great] kings of the day, was the first among them to invade Egypt and wrest it from the hand of Sultan al-Ghawrī, this in the year 923 [1517]. His motivation in so doing was the fact that, having just conquered Syria, he desired to extend his conquests to Iraq, for it was the homeland and residence of his Turkmen forebears. [Salīm] accordingly decamped from Istanbul, his capital, but when he arrived with his forces to Syria, he was unable to provision them adequately due to the great rise in prices in that region; he therefore required provisioning from Egypt and wrote to al-Ghawrī to that effect, requesting to be provisioned from his realm. But when Shah [Ismāʿīl], the king of Persian Iraq at that time, heard of Sultan Salīm's mobilization, he wrote to al-Ghawrī, his ally, asking that he deflect and impede [Salīm] to the extent possible. This request found al-Ghawrī already furious at Sultan Salīm for taking Syria and fearing that he intended to extend his domain to Egypt. (At the time, Egypt was the center of the Islamic world, ruled by its most powerful kings, for the Abbasid caliphate had been transferred there in the wake of the Mon-

31 Al-ʿAyyāshī, *al-Riḥla*, 2:11: *tamahhara fī ʿilm al-ḥisāb wa-l-tawqīt wa-l-tanjīm wa-nfarada fī tilka l-aqtār bi-maʿrifat ʿilm al-sūniyāʾ wa-l-zayārīj wa-l-ḥidhān bi-ṭuruq mutaʿaddida, fa-nāla bi-dhālika wajāhat^{an} ʿind al-umarāʾ wa-arbāb al-manāṣib*. As al-ʿAyyāshī relates, however, he was frustrated in his attempts to learn the science of *jafr* at Ibn al-Tāj's hand, and expresses his frustration with a critique of lettrism more generally. That this Maghribi scholar-Sufi references Ibn Khaldūn's own critique to this end, drawing on both the *Muqaddima* and *Shifāʾ al-sāʿil*, while also allowing for the legitimacy of the science when done by saints, is significant in this context. But despite his reservations, he attempts to present evidence in its support impartially, drawing on Ibn ʿArabī and al-Būnī in particular, as the science's two greatest authorities, and including the anecdote about Kemāl-paṣazāde translated below. For this long section on Ibn al-Tāj, featuring primarily lettrist material, see al-ʿAyyāshī, 2:11–61.

gol catastrophe.) Thus, when Sultan Salim requested provisioning of al-Ghawrī, the latter thought it but a pretext [for invasion], given the timing, and not due to inflation [in Syria]; he therefore declined, offering weak excuses. Salim accordingly divined his intent to prevent him from passing through to Iraq—and now set his sights on the conquest not of Iraq but of Egypt.

To this end, he sought the counsel of the scholars in his retinue, explaining to them his grounds [for attack]: al-Ghawrī had refused him provisioning from Egypt despite his need for it. But they were unanimous: “It is not licit for you to attack him, for he is sovereign in his own realm, has been fully cooperative with your demands [in the past], and has made no declaration of war; how then could it be licit to attack him in his own realm without cause?”

Among those scholars assembled, however, was the penetrating (*al-muhaqqiq*) Ibn Kamāl Bāshā, the most junior of them. He addressed [the sultan]: “Commander, it is indeed licit for you to attack him, for it is in the Book of God that you shall enter Egypt this very year.” [The sultan] replied, “How could that be so?” Said [Ibn Kamāl], “I will not [now] issue a fatwa in the presence of these most esteemed leading scholars of Islam but ask that you delay the matter for a week, until they have had time to contemplate it further. For God Most High has said: *We have neglected nothing in the Book* (Q 6:38)—how then could such a notable event as this not be in the Book of God Most High, which contains the exposition of all things?”

Salim therefore declared to the assembled: “I am delaying the matter for a week, that you might search out the meaning of what he said.” But they remonstrated: “Commander, our answer in a week will be the same as our answer now!” Ibn Kamāl, however, insisted that the delay was necessary. (His purpose in this—though God only knows—was to demonstrate to the king his [scholarly] superiority, his ability to grasp immediately what other [scholars] were unable to even upon reflection; for had he explained himself immediately, they might have claimed that anyone could grasp the matter if given time to reflect.)

Having delayed the matter for a week, Salim reassembled them once it had passed and again asked them [their legal opinion], and [as promised] they replied, “Our verdict then is our verdict now.” But said Ibn Kamāl: “Commander, they have most certainly read in the glorious Book of God that you shall enter Egypt with your army this very year, although they have not understood this fact.” [The assembled scholars] replied, “And where is that?” He answered, “In the Most High’s statement *For We have written in the Psalms, after the Remembrance: My righteous servants shall*

inherit the land." They laughed at this, saying, "What does this have to do with the matter?"

[Ibn Kamāl proceeded to expound]: "The Most High's statement *for (wa-la-qad)* is equivalent to [the name] Salīm by way of gematria (*ḥisāb al-jummal*)—both equal 140. Thus the statement [as a whole] means *Salīm*—*We have written in the Psalms that after [the year] 920 he shall inherit the land.* For *the Psalms (al-dhikr)* equals, minus the definite article, that number. And *the land* here refers, according to many exegetes, to Egypt, while the *righteous servants* of this era are your troops, inasmuch as there are none more upright among the armies of the Muslims in all the regions of the world, this due to their upholding the *sunna* of jihad and their conquest of the larger part of the Christian domains. They are committed to the way of the *sunna* and *jamā'a* more than any other [Muslim] army, whether those of Iraq, whose creed is corrupt, as is that of most of Yemen and India, or those of the Maghrib, whose resolve to uphold the standards of Islam has become weak, or those of Egypt, whom worldly concerns have overmastered."

[Ibn Kamāl] continued in this vein at length, and Sultan Salīm was greatly pleased with his exposition. The other jurists, however, while granting the ingenuity and subtlety of his interpretation, nevertheless rejoined: "This still does not suffice to permit an attack on [a ruler] who has not rebelled or declared war against any Muslims. Even if the quranic allusion does suggest that this will take place, there must still be a proper basis on which to issue a legal opinion." Said Ibn Kamāl, "Commander, this too may be readily found. Simply send a message to Sultan al-Ghawrī as follows: 'When I arrived in this region I was unable to accomplish what I had here intended, so I have purposed rather to make for the Hijaz to perform the rite of pilgrimage. But I have no route nor means of provisioning except through your realm; I therefore desire that you grant me permission to pass through your realm and provision therein.' There is no doubt but that he will forbid and debar you from passing through his realm—and if he debars you from performing the pilgrimage, it becomes licit for you to attack him and declare war."

Thereupon the [assembled] jurists expressed their support (*istaḥsana*) for his [ingenious] opinion on the matter (for their legal school is replete with such casuistry, and the embrace of such [dubious] methods is for them a universal law).³² Sultan Salīm therefore wrote to al-Ghawrī in this

32 I.e., the Hanafi. This snide aside reflects al-'Ayyāshī's Malikism.

wise, who replied in hostile fashion [as predicted]: he strongly declared his refusal, promising that [Salīm] shall not drink even a cupful from the Nile unless it be over the backs of his slain, and other such threats. This but strengthened Sultan Salīm's resolve to attack Egypt, and he began the necessary preparations.

Thus did [Salīm's] conquest of that realm take place, whereby he erased the claim of al-Ghawrī to Egypt, and slaughtered most of her scholars and worthies and many of her officials, including even the Abbasid caliph himself. *But God's command is doom decreed* (Q 33:38). Ibn Kamāl's standing [with the sultan] rose greatly as a consequence, who thereupon offered him his choice of imperial appointments (*al-wilāya*); he chose the muftiship (*al-fatwā*) [of Istanbul], which he was granted, and excelled therein, greatly promoting scholarship and elevating scholars. (May God accept his [labors], amen.)³³

A curious and memorable anecdote indeed—like the thousand similar such scattered throughout early modern Arabo-Perso-Turkish chronicles, biographical dictionaries and other works, and similarly substantiated by uncounted surviving lettrist treatises by scholars famed, like Kemālpaşazāde, or forgotten. Regardless of the authenticity of this particular treatise, it thus accurately reflects an ethos in which the strategic application of occult science was considered an excellent means of securing patronage and climbing the imperial hierarchy. But how precisely does it testify to an Ottoman intellectual-ideological seachange in the early sixteenth century, to the inception of an Ottoman lettrist imperialism?

2 The New Brethren in Cairo, Occult-Scientific Capital of the Persian Cosmopolis

Due to the persistent eurocentrism and arabocentrism of Islamic history as a field, the Ottoman Empire has been far better studied than its rival Persianate empires to the east, Safavid, Uzbek and Mughal (this despite the fact that the last far outstripped it in population and wealth), and the profound depend-

33 Note the rather confused timeline portrayed in al-‘Ayyāshī's telling: Qānṣūh al-Ghawrī (r. 1501–1516) died of stroke during the Battle of Marj Dābiq in August 1516, and so was hardly on hand in Cairo to angrily refuse Selīm's request for passage through Egypt to the Hijaz later that year. The details of Kemālpaşazāde's explication are likewise dropped, including his analysis of the words *ba'd*, *al-zabūr*, *yarithu* and *‘ibādī*.

ence of early Ottoman imperialism and intellectual culture alike on specifically *Timurid-Aqquyunlu* models is still all too rarely acknowledged. Considerably more attention has been paid to its Sunnizing self-definition in opposition to Safavid messianic Shi'i ideology on the one hand and its absorption of Mamluk Arabic high literary culture—with Selīm's conquest of the Sultanate—on the other; Ottoman elite culture, while remaining heavily Persianate, was indeed thenceforth gradually *arabicized* to a certain extent, and increasingly *mediterraneanized*, as it were, the state's expansionist martial vigor trained more on West Europe after Chaldiran. In particular, it inherited Mamluk *encyclopedism*, as well as a book culture that for sheer volume and variety dwarfed its Renaissance Latin cognate to the northwest.³⁴

What is routinely forgotten, however, is that the Mamluk Cairo and Damascus Selīm conquered in the early sixteenth century had themselves been crucial nodes of the Persianate world since the thirteenth: these cities were the vectors by which peculiarly Maghribi intellectual-ideological developments—including in the first place lettrism itself—became hegemonic throughout the post-Mongol persophone east. This basic point, little noted by Mamlukists and hence Ottomanists, has long been appreciated by historians of Sufism, who have tracked the epochal eastward transmission of the (heavily lettrist) thought of Ibn 'Arabī (d. 638/1240) in particular.³⁵ But the still dominant religionist, Corbinian tendency in that field to a) disappear occultism into Sufism and b) depoliticize both, has meant that such a remarkable and robust phenomenon as *Persianate occult-scientific imperialism*, including its Ottoman subset, must magically vanish from historiographical purview. Yet it is precisely that cultural construct, I argue, that serves most strikingly to distinguish post-Mongol Islamicate political theory and practice from pre-Mongol precedent, that helps mark the advent of a Western early modernity.³⁶

We postmodern historians of early modern Islamdom must therefore calm our colonialist mania for drawing borders, for *rupture*, by focusing rather on

34 For references see Melvin-Koushki, "*Tahqīq* vs. *Taqīd*"; Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Of Islamic Grammatology: Ibn Turka's Lettrist Metaphysics of Light," *al-'Uṣūr al-Wuṣṭā* 24 (2016): 42–113.

35 Hailed Doctor Maximus (*al-shaykh al-akbar*) by his admirers and Doctor *infidelissimus* (*al-shaykh al-akfar*) by his detractors, Ibn 'Arabī's strictly monist, Neoplatonic-quranic mystical philosophy pervades post-Mongol Islamicate intellectual history; it constitutes the primary counterweight to mainstream Peripatetic-Illuminationist philosophy and was definitively synthesized with the same in the ninth/fifteenth century by thinkers like Ibn Turka, the preeminent Ibn 'Arabian lettrist (on whom see below).

36 Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "*Tahqīq* vs. *Taqīd*"; Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Imperial Talismanic Love"; Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Early Modern Islamicate Empire."

the astonishing continuities—cosmological, cultural, intellectual, imperial, occultist—that made the vast Persianate world, and indeed the early modern Islamo-Christianate world more broadly, an organic civilizational whole.³⁷ And these continuities were sustained, naturally, by the free circulation of scholars and texts between politically competitive polities, especially via magnetic cosmopolises like Cairo—where the peculiarly western Arabic science of letters was first *sanctified, de-esotericized, adabized, Neopythagoreanized, and imperialized*.³⁸

These processes culminated in the Mamluk capital in the late eighth/fourteenth century, and specifically with a circle of Neopythagoreanizing scholar-occultists—the self-styled New Brethren of Purity—attached to al-Malik al-Zāhir Barqūq's (r. 784–791, 792–801/1382–1389, 1390–1399) court.³⁹ As new research is showing, this “Manifest King” would seem to have been among the first to actively experiment with the occult-scientific modes of sovereignty that would thenceforth be such a distinctive feature of political theory and

37 See Richard Bulliet, *The Case for Islamo-Christian Civilization* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2004); Garth Fowden, *Before and after Muḥammad: The First Millennium Refocused* (Princeton, 2014). On ambiguity, contradiction and continuity as ruling principles in Islamicate societies see Shahab Ahmed, *What Is Islam? The Importance of Being Islamic* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2015); Thomas Bauer, *Die Kultur der Ambiguität* (Berlin: Verlag der Weltreligionen, 2011).

38 For an explanation of these terms, see Melvin-Koushki and Pickett, “Mobilizing Magic,” 248–253. On the sanctification of the occult sciences generally, see Liana Saif, “From *Ġāyat al-hakīm* to *Šams al-ma‘ārif*: Ways of Knowing and Paths of Power in Medieval Islam,” in “Islamicate Occultism: New Perspectives,” ed. Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Noah Gardiner, special double issue of *Arabica* 64, nos. 3–4 (2017): 297–345; on the de-esotericization of lettrism in particular, see Gardiner, “Esotericism”; on the Neopythagoreanization of the same see Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One”; Melvin-Koushki, “The New Brethren of Purity.”; Melvin-Koushki, “World as (Arabic) Text.” On the free circulation of scholars and texts throughout the early modern Persian cosmopolis, see, e.g., Christopher Markiewicz, *The Crisis of Kingship in Late Medieval Islam: Persian Emigres and the Making of Ottoman Sovereignty* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2019); Mana Kia, *Persianate Selves: Memories of Place and Origin Before Nationalism* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2020).

39 This handle is in reference to the original Brethren of Purity (Ikhwān al-Ṣafā') of fourth/tenth-century Iraq, a shadowy group of scholar-bureaucrats whose encyclopedic *Epistles* represent the definitive expression of Islamic occultist Neopythagoreanism in the medieval period. On their decidedly nonshadowy ninth/fifteenth-century heirs, similarly ardent Neopythagoreanizing occultists but unlike them famed scholars and ideologues of empire, see Fleischer, “Ancient Wisdom”; Fazlhoğlu, “İlk Dönem Osmanlı İlimi”; İlker Evrim Binbaş, *Intellectual Networks in Timurid Iran: Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī and the Islamicate Republic of Letters* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), 3–15; Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest,” 16–19; Melvin-Koushki, “The New Brethren of Purity.”

practice in the post-Mongol Persianate world, although no coherent platform was achieved before his death; Barqūq's reign, like those of certain Ilkhanid rivals several decades before, may thus be seen as a trial run for the much bolder occultist imperial platforms developed for Timurid, Aquyunlu, Safavid, Mughal, and Ottoman dynasts over the next three centuries.⁴⁰ Barqūq's personal collection of occult-scientific books and evidently eager patronage of the Brethren aside, perhaps the most telling index of this watershed ideological shift is Ibn Khaldūn (d. 808/1406) himself: that the puritanical and reactionary jurist-historian devoted a full eleven percent of his now-celebrated *Muqaddima* ("Prolegomena") to anti-occultist polemic—declaring (in the final recension prepared for Barqūq) even lettrism to be mere sorcery and hence illegal, meriting capital punishment—testifies precisely to the ascendancy of occultism at his Mamluk patron's court.⁴¹

The Brethren were not, however, themselves Mamluk scholars but Timurid and Ottoman, drawn to Cairo as the intellectual—and especially occult-scientific—capital of Islamdom of that era. The pivot of this highly mobile network of scholar-occultists, the original "Lettrist International,"⁴² was one Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (d. 799/1397); this Tabrizi Kurdish lettrist-alchemist became personal physician to Barqūq and teacher in Cairo to the most influential imperial occultists of the early ninth/fifteenth century, who were, in turn, responsible for the new models of *lettrist imperialism* here in view. Most notably, Akhlāṭī combined in himself the two primary strains of Western sanctified

40 On Ilkhanid ideological experimentation see, e.g., Jonathan Z. Brack, "Mediating Sacred Kingship: Conversion and Sovereignty in Mongol Iran" (PhD diss., University of Michigan, 2016); on the more explicitly occult-scientific platforms of their Persianate successors, see Melvin-Koushki, "Early Modern Islamic Empire."

41 Noah Gardiner, *Ibn Khaldūn versus the Occultists at Barqūq's Court: The Critique of Lettrism in al-Muqaddimah* (Berlin: EB Verlag, 2020); Gardiner, "Occultist Encyclopedism"; Gardiner, "Esotericism," 317–319; Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "In Defense of Geomancy: Šaraf al-Dīn Yazdī Rebuts Ibn Ḥaldūn's Critique of the Occult Sciences," in "Islamic Occultism: New Perspectives," ed. Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Noah Gardiner, special double issue of *Arabica* 64, nos. 3–4 (2017): 346–403.

42 In current Europeanist scholarship, the term "lettrism" (unlike its sister science kabbalah) is associated almost exclusively with the modern French surrealist movement of the same name, founded in Paris in the mid-1940s by Isidore Isou (d. 2007), a schismatic branch of which termed itself the Lettrist International. While an important aspect of fourteenth/twentieth-century French avant-garde culture, lettrism as a mainstream Western (Islam-Judeo-Christianate) phenomenon, like its sister science kabbalah, is of far greater historical significance and influence than is implied by its modern, very limited reception in France. Terminologically, moreover, "lettrist" translates precisely the frequent self-designation of the practitioners of this science as *ḥarfis* or *ahl al-ḥarf* and is thus both a first-order and a second-order term.

lettrism as consolidated in Egypt by the fourteenth century: lettrist theory, associated with Ibn ‘Arabī, Andalusī Doctor Maximus, and lettrist praxis, associated with the Ifriqiyan Sufi-mage Aḥmad al-Būnī (d. btw. 622–630/1225–1233).

Akhḷāṭī’s own surviving works, however, are exclusively in a practical, Būnian vein and feature no explicit imperialist agenda. It would be left to his greatest Timurid student and deputy (*khalīfa*) in the east, Ibn Turka of Isfahan (d. 835/1432), to systematize fully Ibn ‘Arabian lettrism, unprecedentedly in service to a series of Timurid sovereigns.⁴³ Similarly, Būnian lettrism would be exhaustively consolidated for the benefit of their Ottoman rivals by ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī (d. 858/1454), Antiochene associate of Akhlāṭī’s student and Ottoman *khalīfa* Shaykh Badr al-Dīn (Bedreddīn) of Simavna (executed 823/1420), himself the infamous Ibn ‘Arabianizing ideologue behind what came to be known as the most successful rebellion in early Ottoman history.⁴⁴ Where Ibn Turka’s lettrist oeuvre is philosophically rigorously systematizing and presents its science as a new millenarian physics-metaphysics trumping Peripatetic-

43 On Ibn Turka as occult philosopher and metaphysical revolutionary, see Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest”; Melvin-Koushki, “Ibn Turka,” *Encyclopaedia of Islam*, 3rd ed.

44 On the development of Būnian lettrism and its afterlives, see Gardiner, “Esotericism.” While Shaykh Badr al-Dīn has attracted a measure of scholarly attention in recent decades (see most recently Ahmet Y. Ocak, *Osmanlı Toplumunda Zındıklar ve Mülhüdler* (15.–17. Yüzyıllar), 4th ed. (Istanbul: Türkiye Ekonomik ve Toplumsal Tarih Vakfı, 2013), 159–235)—certainly far more than any other member of the New Brethren of Purity—the strongly Ibn ‘Arabian tenor of the millenarian-utopian project put forward in his famed *Wāridāt* (“Inspirations”) has yet to be adequately appreciated or read in tandem with the writings of his close colleague Ibn Turka in a similar vein. But the latter—and, following him, Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī—expressly imperializes Ibn ‘Arabī’s *tawḥīd* for the benefit of their Timurid patrons; Badr al-Dīn rather wielded it to subvert or challenge still tenuous Ottoman imperial claims. A representative passage, here commenting on Q 20:105–107 (*They will question you concerning the mountains. Say: “My Lord will scatter them as ashes; then He will leave them a level hollow wherein you shall see no crookedness nor any curving”*) (MS Izmir 304, fol. 24^a; MS Hacı Mahmud Efendi 2574, fol. 15^a; cf. Binbaş, *Intellectual Networks*, 122–132—this passage is translated entirely incorrectly at 129):

This may be taken as referring to the manifestation of Essence (*al-dhāt*) and the propagation of Oneness (*al-tawḥīd*) at the end of time; then shall rule belong [solely] to the One Essence (*al-dhāt al-wāḥid*) wherein is no crookedness (*‘iwaj*), and its dominion will remove the mountains that are the Attributes (*jibāl al-sifāt*). The master of this age (*ṣāhib hādihā l-zamān* = Mahdi) will be a site of manifestation of absolute Oneness and will call all humanity thereto; he shall not be inclined to hide it, thereby deviating (*‘rwiḳā*) [from perfect balance] but shall rather prepare hearts and [all] sites of manifestation for the Attributes to receive the rulings of the Essence, called God (*Allāh*) and the All-Merciful (*al-Raḥmān*). He shall manifest the rulings of the Essence and shall occult those of the Attributes, and no longer shall [the latter’s] effects be besought as once they were.

Illuminationist philosophy and Sufi theory both, al-Biṣṭāmī's is traditionist, apocalypticist, Sufi-friendly and encyclopedic, which is to say quintessentially *Mamluk*.

Ibn 'Arabian-Būnian lettrism thus diverged in the city that first imperially fostered it, Cairo, with Ibn Turkian lettrist theory becoming dominant in scholarly-courtly discourse to the east and Biṣṭāmian lettrist praxis to the north during the course of the fifteenth century; but with Selīm's conquest of that city in 1517—and Kemālpaşazāde's lettrist urging to that end—the two currents reconverged.

Famously, in taking Damascus a few months prior, Selīm had declared Ibn 'Arabī the patron saint of the Ottoman Empire, pointedly fulfilling the Greatest Master's putative prophecy: "When the S (i.e., Selīm) enters the Sh (i.e., Shām, Damascus) shall the tomb of Muḥyī l-Dīn be found."⁴⁵ This prophecy was enshrined in the pseudepigraphal *al-Shajara al-nu'māniyya fī l-dawla al-'Uthmāniyya* ("The Crimson Tree: On Ottoman Glory"), a cryptic *jafrī* text probably produced by a member of al-Biṣṭāmī's circle in the mid- to late ninth/fifteenth century, together with commentary ascribed to Ibn 'Arabī's protégé Ṣadr al-Dīn Qūnawī (d. 673/1274), which accurately predicted Selīm's conquest of the Mamluk sultanate in the early tenth/sixteenth. On this basis, it proclaims the Ottoman Empire midwife of the eschaton, the last world empire in history.⁴⁶ *The Crimson Tree* accordingly became a crucial prop to the Ottoman occult-scientific, universalist imperialism developed under Süleymān. Similarly, as Fleischer has shown, al-Biṣṭāmī's *Miftāḥ al-jafr al-jāmī* ("Key to the Comprehensive Prognosticon") came to function as urtext for the fashioning of the Ottoman Lawgiver as last world emperor during the expansive first decades of his rule and was even adopted as a dynastic handbook, with portable copies proliferating at court.⁴⁷

Early modern Ottoman universalist imperialism is, in short, largely illegible absent an intellectual-historical understanding of Ibn 'Arabian-Būnian lettrism as developed between the Mamluk, Timurid, and Ottoman realms during the

45 Ps.-Ibn 'Arabī, *al-Shajara al-nu'māniyya fī l-dawla al-'Uthmāniyya*, ed. 'Āṣim Ibrāhīm al-Kayyālī (Beirut: Dār al-Kutub al-'Ilmiyya, 2011), 30.

46 See Denis Gril, "L'énigme de la *Šağara al-nu'māniyya fī l-dawla al-'uthmāniyya*, attribuée à Ibn 'Arabī," in *Les traditions apocalyptiques au tournant de la chute de Constantinople*, ed. Benjamin Lellouch and Stéphane Yerasimos (Paris: L'Harmattan, 2000), 133–152; Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom," 239. That this is an Ikhwānī text, or was meant to be perceived as such, would seem to be confirmed by its opening address: *i'lām ayyuhā l-akh al-ṣafī wa-l-khill al-waḥī* ("Know, pure brother and faithful friend ...").

47 Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom," 238–239; Fleischer, "A Mediterranean Apocalypse," 24, 44–47.

eighth/fourteenth and ninth/fifteenth centuries. *History of empire* requires *history of science*.

That Ibn ‘Arabī in particular has been studied almost exclusively within a history of Sufism—that is, history of religion—framework thus constitutes a major historiographical stumblingblock; this epochal *imperialization of Ibn ‘Arabian science* is thereby obscured. Historians of Sufism, to be sure, have shown Ibn ‘Arabī’s Neoplatonic doctrine of spiritual governance—a cosmically hierarchical system culminating in a single Pole (*quṭb*), one per generation, the supreme human being and *axis mundi*—to have had major implications for the development of post-Mongol Islamic political theory, including its Ottoman subset; early modern Muslim sovereigns accordingly jockeyed for the specifically Ibn ‘Arabian titles *quṭb al-aqṭāb* (“Pole of Poles”) and *al-insān al-kāmil* (“the Perfect Man”) as a primary expression of their universalist ambitions.⁴⁸ But specialists have not yet appreciated the full extent to which the Greatest Master was transformed into the ultimate ideologue of early modern universalist imperialism—precisely in his reception, from Ibn Turka forward, as chiefest authority on lettrism in Islamic history (with al-Būnī and after Imams ‘Alī and Ja’far al-Šādiq). For *universal empire* requires a *universal science* to back it: Ibn ‘Arabian *tawḥīd*, the “science of making One,” recast by the New Brethren in strictly lettrist-imperialist and Neopythagorean-mathematizing terms.⁴⁹

Here Kemālpaşazāde’s status as a major interpreter, defender, and routinizer of Ibn ‘Arabī takes on a new salience: this is the immediate sociopolitical and epistemological context in which his lettrist treatise—calling, like the *The Crimson Tree* and al-Biṣṭāmī’s *Key*, for the conquest precisely of Cairo—must be understood.⁵⁰ Pithy, assured, and punchy, it signals Ibn ‘Arabī’s

48 See, e.g., Michel Chodkiewicz, “The Esoteric Foundations of Political Legitimacy in Ibn ‘Arabī,” in *Muhyiddin Ibn ‘Arabī: A Commemorative Volume*, ed. Stephen Hirtenstein and Michael Tiernan (Shaftesbury: Element, 1993), 190–198; Adam Sabra, “The Cosmic State: Ibn al-‘Arabī’s Political Theology,” unpublished paper (2015); Aziz Al-Azmeh, *Muslim Kingship: Power and the Sacred in Muslim, Christian and Pagan Politics* (London: I.B. Tauris, 2001), 198–200; cf. Vincent J. Cornell, *Realm of the Saint: Power and Authority in Moroccan Sufism* (Austin: University of Texas Press, 1998). Cf. Melvin-Koushki, “Early Modern Islamic Empire”; Gregory A. Lipton, *Rethinking Ibn ‘Arabī* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018).

49 The term *tawḥīd* (absolute monotheism) is often broadly equated with Islam as such. On lettrism’s new early modern status as universal science, see Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest”; for comparison with Latin European developments, particularly the quest to realize the millenarian Catholic religio-imperial dictum *unum ovile et unus pastor* (“one sheepfold and one shepherd”), see Melvin-Koushki, *The Occult Science of Empire*.

50 On Kemālpaşazāde as key defender of Ibn ‘Arabī, see Ahmed Zildzic, “Friend and Foe:

imperialization in an Ottoman mode, made possible by Selim's conquest of Damascus in fulfillment of a ninth/fifteenth-century Bistāmian lettrist prophecy.

3 Mamluk-Timurid-Aqquyunlu Neopythagorean Historiography Ottomanized

The problem our treatise presents the modern materialist researcher is thus less a philological than a cosmological one: it testifies to a worldview in which occult science demonstrably and experimentally works, to a theory of history that is explicitly Neopythagorean, wherein letter-number figures as key to the control—especially imperial—of time and space. Can we speak, then, of the rise of a *Neopythagorean historiography*?

I believe we must: this text, and much of early modern Persianate imperial-scholarly culture by extension, otherwise remains illegible. For the same Neopythagorean-occultist cosmology that underlies Kemālpaşazāde's brief lettrist treatise for Selīm animates precisely some of the most admired and influential Perso-Turkish imperial histories of the ninth/fifteenth and tenth/sixteenth centuries. This includes our scholar-ideologue's own landmark *Tevārīḥ-i āl-i 'Osmān* ("Annals of the Ottoman House"), the first Turkish history of the Ottoman dynasty to accord with the contemporary high Persian model, both stylistically pellucid and thoroughly comfortable with Ibn 'Arabian philosophy and occult science alike.⁵¹

This new tradition of Persian Neopythagorean-occultist historiography was inaugurated, not surprisingly, by another member of the New Brethren, Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī (d. 858/1454), Ibn Turka's student and friend, and fellow disciple

The Early Ottoman Reception of Ibn 'Arabī" (PhD diss., University of California, Berkeley, 2012); Tim Winter, "Ibn Kemāl (d. 940/1534) on Ibn 'Arabī's Hagiology," in *Sufism and Theology*, ed. Ayman Shihadeh (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2007), 137–157. More generally, see Alexander D. Knysh, *Ibn 'Arabi in the Later Islamic Tradition: The Making of a Polemical Image in Medieval Islam* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1999); Knysh notes (p. 4) that Kemālpaşazāde, in his role as imperial chief jurisconsult, was responsible for issuing the first ban on the public defamation of Ibn 'Arabī in the Ottoman domains.

⁵¹ Markiewicz, *The Crisis*, 92–93; Şen, "Practicing Astral Magic," 85–86. On the New Brethren as the leading Arabic and Persian prose stylists of the early ninth/fifteenth century, and lettrism as natural theoretical basis for the ornate literary and visual cultures peculiar to Persianate early modernity, see Melvin-Koushki, "Of Islamic Grammatology," 76, 78–80.

of Akhlāṭī in Cairo. Lettrist, litterateur, and mathematician, Yazdī achieved his greatest fame as dynastic historian to the Timurids; his *Zafarnāma*, an ornate Persian history of Temūr (r. 771–807/1370–1405) completed in 839/1436, was much imitated for centuries thereafter throughout the Persianate world.⁵² What has not yet been noted by specialists, however, is the fact that Yazdī's *Book of Conquest* is predicated on a new, expressly occult-philosophical theory of history, wherein lettrism and conjunction astrology serve not as sources for mere rhetorical embellishment but rather as macrohistorical analytical framework, indispensable tools for penetrating the phenomenal surface of historical events to get at their cosmic meaning, for cracking the code of cyclical time.⁵³ In other words: Yazdī here *makes history an (occult) science*.

Utterly without Islamicate and broader Western precedent, such a daring move should be seen as part of a larger Arabo-Persian scholarly trend during the ninth/fifteenth and tenth/sixteenth centuries toward reformulating history as a proper and rigorous science, even as supreme among the literary sciences, as Christopher Markiewicz has now shown.⁵⁴ It is no accident that this new impetus to theorize imperial historiography coincided with the great burgeoning of occultism and Neopythagoreanism at the hands of the New Brethren, three of whom—al-Biṣṭāmī, Ibn Turka, and Yazdī—stand as some of the most influential imperial ideologues, Ottoman and Timurid respectively, of the ninth/fifteenth century; and Yazdī and al-Biṣṭāmī were the first to apply Ikhwānī doctrine to the science of history.⁵⁵

This Yazdī did, I have elsewhere argued, in direct rebuttal of Ibn Khaldūn's 'science of civilization' (*ʿilm al-ʿumrān*), predicated on a simplistic theory of dynastic cycling, which superficially resembles Yazdī's own cyclical theory of

52 Yazdī also began four other chronicles, including a *Muqaddima*, *Faṭḥ-nāma-yi šāhib-qirānī*, *Faṭḥ-nāma-yi humāyūn*, and the *Second Maqāla*, none of which he finished and whose shifting ideological strategies reflect the displacement of Temūr's dispensation with that of his son Shāhrukh (Binbaş, *Intellectual Networks*, 199–250).

53 Melvin-Koushki, "In Defense of Geomancy" and "Imperial Talismanic Love."

54 Markiewicz, "History as Science: The Fifteenth-Century Debate in Arabic and Persian," *Journal of Early Modern History* 21 (2017): 216–240. Cf. Giambattista Vico's (d. 1744) historiographical marriage of philology and philosophy in his *New Science*.

55 The original Brethren of Purity of fourth/tenth-century Iraq similarly formulated a Neopythagorean, cyclical theory of history heavily astrological in tenor; but, unlike their ninth/fifteenth-century heirs, they left lettrism to the Sufis and operated in strict anonymity—that is to say, they certainly did not serve as *imperial lettrist historians* in the manner of Yazdī and al-Biṣṭāmī. On the latter's even more thoroughly lettrist world history, *Naẓm al-sulūk fī musāmarat al-mulūk* ("Regulation of Conduct: On the Edification of Kings"), which is as anti-Timurid as Yazdī's is pro-, see Noah Gardiner's Chapter 6 in the present volume.

history. (It must again be emphasized that both historians were members of Barqūq's court in Cairo.) But where the latter deploys lettrism and astrology within a monist-Ibn 'Arabian framework to trace the deeper patterns of cosmic time, robustly theorizing *imperial transcendence* as a necessary historical expression of the One, the strictly dualist leveling theory proposed by his Tunisian colleague and rival, a rabid anti-occultist, rather condemns dynasts to be forever ground under by the cycling of history between two sociological poles. Ibn Khaldūn simply moralizes, imprisoning political actors in the binaries of time and the strictures of Shari'a; he offers in return only the humble rewards that accrue through the strict enforcement of piety on an always erring society. But Yazdī promises to historically empower and spiritually perfect—to *divinize*—its royal patrons by means of Ibn 'Arabian occult science. Not only can the future be read by the aspiring (occult) philosopher-king: it can also be *rewritten*.⁵⁶

The latter prospect could not but be far more attractive than the former to the ambitious millennial sovereigns of the post-Mongol era.⁵⁷ Ibn Khaldūn's depressing, stridently anti-millenarian, anti-Ibn 'Arabian, and anti-occultist "science of civilization" was thus roundly ignored by scholars until the middle of the more sedate eleventh/seventeenth century, when Ottoman historians first began to cite it in support of their own theories of dynastic cycling.⁵⁸ Even the Mamluk historian Taqī l-Dīn al-Maqrīzī (d. 845/1442), Ibn Khaldūn's student and sole defender and an enthusiastic occultist nevertheless, sought to combine his mentor's model with the Yazdian.⁵⁹

56 Melvin-Koushki, "In Defense of Geomancy." Cf. Ibn Turka's *Munāzara-yi bazm u razm* ("Debate of Feast and Fight"), written in 1426 for the Timurid prince and calligrapher Bāysunghur b. Shāhrukh (d. 1434), which similarly argues for Timurid imperial transcendence in explicitly lettrist terms; it is studied and translated in Melvin-Koushki, "Imperial Talismanic Love."

57 On the category of millennial sovereignty in the Timurid-Mughal context, see A. Azfar Moin, *The Millennial Sovereign: Sacred Kingship and Sainthood in Islam* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2012).

58 Cornell Fleischer, "Royal Authority, Dynastic Cyclism, and 'Ibn Khaldūnism' in Ottoman Letters," *Journal of Asian and African Studies* 18, nos. 3–4 (1983): 198–220, esp. 199. On Ibn Khaldūn's opposition to Ibn 'Arabī as a primary cause for his irrelevance to early modern Islamicate and especially Persianate scholarly culture, see James Winston Morris, "An Arab Machiavelli? Rhetoric, Philosophy and Politics in Ibn Khaldun's Critique of Sufism," *Harvard Middle Eastern and Islamic Review* 8 (2009): 242–291.

59 As Robert Irwin summarizes al-Maqrīzī's historiographical project ("Al-Maqrīzī and Ibn Khaldūn, Historians of the Unseen," *Mamlūk Studies Review* 7, no. 2 (2003): 217–230, esp. 230): "History was at the core of his oeuvre, but occult and eschatological concerns were at the core of his history." See also Nasser Rabbat, "Was al-Maqrīzī's *Khīṭaṭ* a Khaldūnian History?" *Der Islam* 89, no. 2 (2012): 118–140.

But the precedent Yazdī set was irreducibly *Timurid*. Most notably, he is responsible for the definitive Timuridization of the astrological title Lord of Conjunction (*ṣāhib-qirān*)—by means of *lettrist* argument.⁶⁰ That is to say, Yazdī is the first historian in the Arabo-Persian tradition to construct a dual astrological-lettrist platform in support of his patrons' imperial legitimacy, whereby the analysis of a dynast's horoscope must be paired with the lettrist analysis of names and events, especially as they relate to quranic passages, and particularly the sura-initial *muqatta'āt*. (Ibn Turka, demonstrating the imperial utility of his science in *Su'l al-mulūk* ("Query of Kings"), prognosticated, accurately as it happened, that the Timurid state would endure for the entirety of the ninth Islamic century on the basis of Shāhrukh b. Temür's (r. 811–850/1409–1447) name alone.⁶¹) Thus Temür, in Yazdī's *deep reading* of history, is not only supreme Muslim Lord of Conjunction, preordained world conqueror, and second Alexander; he is also an epoch-making historical manifestation of both the *coincidentia oppositorum* (*majma' al-aḍḍād*)—primary principle of Ibn Turka's lettrist metaphysics—and the quranic *ALM*.⁶²

Any effective challenge to this new, *scientific* Timurid vocabulary of sovereignty would therefore require the counterdeployment of astrological and lettrist arguments; and that challenge was first raised—albeit more eclectically—by scholar-ideologues serving the rival Aqquyunlu Empire. These include, in the first place, Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī (d. 908/1502), famed Shirazi philosopher and Ibn Turkian lettrist,⁶³ and two of his students, court secretary-historians in the Aqquyunlu chancery: Faḡl Allāh Khunjī Iṣfahānī (d. 927/1521) and Idrīs Bidlīsī (d. 926/1520). (Both men, significantly, had sojourned in Cairo.) As an opening salvo, Davānī sought to sidestep and undercut Yazdī's lettrist arguments in the *Ẓafarnāma* by seizing upon the opening verses of Sūrat al-Rūm ("The Byzantines," Q 30:1–5),⁶⁴ the only explicit political prediction in the Quran, to prove Uzun Ḥasan's (r. 861–882/1457–1478) *cosmic* superiority to

60 Binbaş, *Intellectual Networks*, 255; Melvin-Koushki, "In Defense of Geomancy."

61 Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 254, 527.

62 Yazdī, *Ẓafarnāma*, ed. Sa'īd Mīr-Muḥammad Ṣādiq and 'Abd al-Ḥusayn Navā'ī, 2 vols. (Tehran: Mīrās-i Maktūb, 1387sh/2008), 1:236–238, 404–405, 2:1295; these passages are translated in Melvin-Koushki, "In Defense of Geomancy," 388–391. On the *ALM* see n. 21 above.

63 On Davānī as lettrist, see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 247–261; Melvin-Koushki, *The Occult Science of Empire*.

64 *ALM*. *The Byzantines (al-Rūm) have been vanquished in the nearer part of the land, and, after their vanquishing, they shall vanquish in a few years. God's is the Command before and after, and on that day the believers shall rejoice in God's help. God helps whomsoever He will; He is the Almighty, the All-compassionate.*

Temür, and hence the historical inevitability of Aqquyunlu imperial supremacy within Islamdom; this became the linchpin of Aqquyunlu ideology as expressed in diplomatic correspondence and historiography thenceforward. In particular, Khunjī's *Tārīkh-i 'ālam-ārā-yi amīnī* ("Aminian World-Adorning History"), an ornate Persian history of the dynasty expressly on the model of Yazdī's, adds to Davānī's lettrist counterargument others of a similarly occult-scientific tenor, as well as innovative legal arguments in support of the Aqquyunlu dynasts' status as messianic centenary Renewers (sg. *mujaddid*), a venerable title Yazdī had likewise helped politicize and Timuridize.⁶⁵

Historical circumstance, however, soon disqualified these arguments, occult-scientific or otherwise; the Aqquyunlu empire self-destructed during the last decade of the late ninth-early tenth/fifteenth century through civil war, and with the Safavid conquest in 1501–1502 of Tabriz, the Aqquyunlu imperial capital, Khunjī and Bidlīsī chose self-exile rather than serve the new and unpredictable Qizilbāsh regime.⁶⁶ As consummate court scholar-ideologues and exponents of High Persianate culture, they readily found royal patronage elsewhere—Khunjī to the northeast, at the Uzbek court, Bidlīsī to the northwest, at the Ottoman. Khunjī became the leading light first of Shībani Khan's (r. 906–918/1500–1512) and then 'Ubayd Allāh Khan's (r. 940–946/1534–1539) retinue, from which vantage point he passionately pleaded with all Sunni patrons within reach of his eloquent pen—pinning his final, frustrated hopes on Selīm—to cleanse his beloved Iran of the Safavid Shi'ī plague; Bidlīsī was commissioned by Bāyezīd II himself, that great institutionalizer of astrology, to write the first comprehensive Persian history of the Ottoman dynasty, the *Hasht bihisht* ("Eight Paradises").

Like Yazdī's *Book of Conquest* and Khunjī's *Aminian World-Adorner* before it, Bidlīsī's *Eight Paradises*, completed in 912/1506, is a gorgeous and highly complex work of historiography that focuses on the "cosmically ordained and universally applicable signs of Ottoman superiority," drawing upon "a wide array of astrological, mystical, philosophical, and occult doctrines and [freely mixing] ideas from these varied traditions to create a compelling and universalizing conception of kingship."⁶⁷ To this end, for example, it ontologically

65 John E. Woods, *The Aqquyunlu: Clan, Confederation, Empire*, rev. ed. (Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press, 1999), 102–106, 145; Melvin-Koushki, "The Delicate Art."

66 See Woods, *The Aqquyunlu*, ch. 6. As Markiewicz notes, however, Bidlīsī was less doctrinaire and more pragmatic than his fervently anti-Safavid colleague Khunjī, and, even as late as 1511, still "entertained the possibility of a full reconciliation with Shah Ismā'īl" (*The Crisis*, 73).

67 Markiewicz, *The Crisis*, 234, 240. The latter quotation refers in Markiewicz's study rather

equates—in unmistakably Neopythagorean fashion—Bāyezīd with the eighth and highest celestial sphere, where the totality of existents first take shape. And that Ottoman sovereign, not Temür, is the greatest Lord of Conjunction of the last age—a point easily proved by an analysis of Bāyezīd's horoscope.⁶⁸ Bidlīsī also pointedly retools Davānī's and Khunjī's lettrist argument for Ottoman purposes: the Sūrat al-Rūm prophecy, he shows at length, cannot refer to Uzun Ḥasan's defeat of the Timurid Abū Sa'īd (r. 855–873/1451–1469) at the Battle of Muş in 1467 but rather to Fātiḥ Meḥmed's (r. 848–850, 855–886/1444–1446, 1451–1481) victory over Uzun Ḥasan at Otlukbeli in 877/1473.⁶⁹ In this, significantly, he would appear to be following the precedent of Mollā Lūtfī (d. 900/1494), Kemālpaşazāde's teacher, who did the same in his Arabic encyclopedia of the linguistic sciences, *al-Maṭālib al-ilāhiyya fī mawḍū'āt al-'ulūm al-lughawīyya*.⁷⁰

to the unprecedented eclecticism of the Timurid model, here exemplified by Yazdī and emulated by Khunjī and Bidlīsī.

68 Bidlīsī, *Hasht bihisht*, Süleymaniye MS Nuruosmaniye 3209, fols. 497^b, 498^b; Markiewicz, *The Crisis*, 267; Şen, "Reading the Stars."

69 Bidlīsī, *Hasht bihisht*, Süleymaniye MS Nuruosmaniye 3209, fol. 470^b; Melvin-Koushki, "The Delicate Art"; 211–212; Markiewicz, *The Crisis*, 183–184.

70 On whom see Taşköprizāde, *al-Shaqā'iq*, 248–251, no. 214; Winter, "Ibn Kemāl," 142. Mollā Lūtfī's encyclopedia has been published as *Dil Bilimlerinin Sınıflandırılması*, ed. Şükran Fazlıoğlu (Istanbul: Kitabevi, 2012); my thanks to Tunç Şen for this reference. I translate the relevant passage for its salience here as the earliest known Ottoman lettrist interpretation of the Sūrat al-Rūm prophecy (edition 101–104):

As for the statement "its benefit is beholding the secrets of the Quran": Among the secrets of His Speech that God Most High gave me to know is the following. When al-Ḥasan the Tall advanced on Tokat, my hometown, I was at that time librarian to the supreme sultan and conquerer of Constantinople, Sultan Meḥmed Ghāzī (God rest him in peace at his sublime threshold), and it grieved me sorely. But in the face of this attack God inspired me to reassure [the sultan with His promise] *God shall help you mightily* (Q 48:3). He further inspired me to calculate the gematrical value of the letters of this verse in the *abjad* system, and, when I did so, I found it to be the same as the coming year [i.e., 878 (1473–1474 CE)]. I accordingly informed the supreme sultan that he should attack that tyrant next year, and all happened as I predicted. I composed a couplet in Persian [to mark the event], as follows:

Routed is the army of Uzun Ḥasan
at the indomitable hand of our shah.
I predicted the date of this by saying, "O Shah,
God shall help you with a mighty help!"

I presented myself to his eminence during the days of conquest, and he honored me with favors beyond counting. For also among [the verse's] rare properties is the fact that it was addressed to Muḥammad (peace be upon him)—and our sultan's name is that of the Prophet, as though he too were the addressee of this declaration.

Likewise, I was inspired to interpret His saying *ALM. The Byzantines have been*

The *Hasht bihisht*, in short, represents a masterful and polemical Ottomanization of the Timurid-Aqquyunlu tradition of Neopythagorean-occultist historiography for the benefit of his rival patron.⁷¹ By way of his teacher Davānī, Bidlisī was doubtlessly well acquainted with the monist, lettrist-astrological theory of history developed in Cairo a century prior by the New Brethren of Purity and aggressively and effectively utilized in support first of Timurid universalist claims and then of Aqquyunlu counterclaims. That this bold Persian masterwork became, in turn, the model for the new, more ornate mode of Ottoman historiography in Turkish that became standard thereafter is therefore of the highest salience in the present context: for Kemālpaşazāde's *Tevārīḫ-i āl-i 'Osmān*, first presented at court in 916/1510 and completed by 932/1526, is the first Turkish history of the Ottoman dynasty to be patterned on Bidlisī's Persian offering of 912/1506 (explicitly and concurrently commissioned by Bāyezīd as such)—and so inherited the latter's cosmic and occult-scientific orientation, if only in part.⁷²

There is a further smoking Ikhwānī gun, one of more immediate Ottoman manufacture. In his autobiographical *Durrat tāj al-rasā'il* ("Pearl in the Diadem of Tractates"), al-Bisṭāmī himself, preeminent source of Ottoman imperial lettrism, proposes a startlingly new classification for the discipline of history (*ilm al-akhbār wa-l-siyar*): he moves it from the traditional (*naqlī*) sciences—

vanquished in the nearer part of the land; and after their vanquishing they shall vanquish in a few years (Q 30:1–4) [as follows]: the nearer part of the land (*adnā l-arḍ*) means the last of the phrase's letters according to logograph methodology (*ṭarīqat al-ta'mīya*) [i.e., *ḍ*], and by that letter is meant its name, that is, *dād*, whose value is 805 [1402 CE]—precisely the year [New] Byzantium (*Rūm*) was vanquished by Tamerlane, who attacked Sultan Yıldırım Khān Bāyezīd at the beginning of Muḥarram of '05. I then calculated the word *a few* (*bid'*), adding the name of *b* (*bā* = 3) to that of *ḍ* (= 805) and its [final letter] ' (= 70), also equivalent to the year of the vanquishing of that tyrant. Thereupon I informed [the sultan] of this glad tidings before its realization, and he pledged me the most munificent of favors, and fulfilled his pledge when matters turned out [as I had said]. A further subtle indication of this verse is the fact that this tyrant attacked a contingent of our victorious army in the nearer part of the land, according to its literal sense [i.e., the Jazira], a week before his total rout; the verse thus refers to that [related] event as well.

71 Unsurprisingly, the same strategy was likewise *Safavidized*: witness Siyāqī Nizām's (d. 1603) *Futūḥāt-i humāyūn* ("Imperial conquests"), a Persian history whose introduction mounts precisely a lettrist defense of Shah 'Abbās the Great's (r. 1587–1629) imperial legitimacy (Sholeh A. Quinn, *Historical Writing during the Reign of Shah 'Abbas: Ideology, Imitation, and Legitimacy in Safavid Chronicles* (Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press, 2000), 46–53).

72 Markiewicz, *The Crisis*, 232–234; Şen, "Practicing Astral Magic," 85–86; Şen, "Reading the Stars."

where every other Arabic and Persian encyclopedist had classed it to date—to the rational (*‘aqlī*) sciences, and specifically the *applied mathematical sciences*. Equally tellingly, he there allies history with the occult sciences of bibliomancy (*‘ilm al-fa’l*), magic and amuletry (*‘ilm al-siḥr wa-l-‘azā’im*), and alchemy and engineering (*‘ilm al-kīmiyā’ wa-l-ḥiyāl*), on the one hand, and the linguistic sciences of prosody (*‘ilm al-‘arūd*), lexicography (*‘ilm al-lughā*), grammar (*‘ilm al-naḥw*), and writing (*‘ilm al-kitāba*), on the other, as well as economics (*‘ilm al-bay’ wa-l-shirā*).⁷³ To thus “mathematicalize” history, to suggest its object as linguistic construct in high lettrist fashion, is to argue for the discipline’s status as applied Neopythagorean-occult science.⁷⁴ Kemālpaşazāde, following Yazdī, Khunjī, and Bidlisī, was among those persuaded by this revolutionary Biṣṭāmian-Ibn Turkian argument; he too pursued *history as science*.

And here we have come full circle: any intellectual history of Turko-Persianate imperial lettrist historiography must always come back to Cairo, its birthplace—a fact of which Kemālpaşazāde and his patron Selīm were clearly aware. Having witnessed and strongly encouraged Selīm’s seizing upon Ibn ‘Arabī as Ottoman patron saint with the conquest of Damascus, moreover, it is not suprising that our ambitious scholar-ideologue thought it most appropriate to push too for the conquest of Cairo in purely Ibn ‘Arabian—that is to say lettrist—terms.⁷⁵ The short treatise he may have produced to this end, substantiating an episode that still lives on in popular and scholarly memory, is thus an ephemeral offering whose significance far outstrips its lack of readership: for it fostered in Selīm the *lettrist consciousness* that was to pervade Ottoman imperial ideology for some four decades thereafter.

Nor was Kemālpaşazāde, following Bidlisī, the only Ottoman scholar-ideologue to adopt this strategy in a bid to win Selīm’s patronage. A similarly ephemeral offering was made to the Ottoman conqueror by Kemālpaşazāde’s

73 MS Nuruosmaniye 4905, fol. 20^b; my thanks to Cornell Fleischer for this reference. Suggestively, Taşköprizāde (d. 1561) too classes the various historiographical sciences with the linguistic sciences, though not with any occult sciences and certainly not under the rubric of applied mathematics, despite his clear reliance on Ibn Turka and al-Biṣṭāmī both; see n. 86 below.

74 Al-Biṣṭāmī’s startling move epitomizes a longer process peculiar to Persian scholarly culture, whereby encyclopedists, from Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī (d. 1209) onward, increasingly shifted various occult sciences (particularly astrology, lettrism, and geomancy) from the natural to the mathematical sciences in classifications of the sciences (sg. *taṣnīf al-‘ulūm*)—the surest index of the renaissance of Neopythagoreanism here in view. This process is traced and its implications for history of science explored in Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One.”

75 As noted, Kemālpaşazāde is responsible for issuing the first Ottoman fatwa, on Selīm’s orders, in defense of Ibn ‘Arabī (Zildzic, “Friend and Foe,” 116–119, 133–142).

colleague Aḥmed Paşa b. Hızır Beğ (d. 927/1521), mufti of Bursa,⁷⁶ only a year or two prior, in the form of a letter of congratulation (*tehniyetnâme*) celebrating Selim's crushing of the Safavids at Chaldiran. Preserved as MS Topkapı Sarayı Müzesi Arşivi E. 4796 and also written in a heavily Persianizing Turkish, this letter develops an image of the Ottoman conqueror as messianic Alexandrian-Solomonic-Jamshidian sovereign and ultimate Lord of Conjunction—indeed “a magic-ringed Solomon upholding the world” (*cihānbān-ı Süleymān-negīn*)—likewise on a strictly occult-scientific (lettrist and oneiromantic) basis.⁷⁷ Crucially, Müfti Aḥmed Paşa too takes a page from Bidlīsī and Mollā Lūṭfī, reanalyzing the Sūrat al-Rūm prophecy to show it to refer rather to Chaldiran—the genesis of Ottoman claims to *universal* empire. As he exclaims in closing:

This *manifest conquest* (*bu feth-i mübīn*) ... shall abide until the Day of Judgment as proof of [the possibility of] achieving universal conquests (*fütūḥāt-ı küllīyye*) and realizing ambitions that are total (*mürādāt-ı cümliyye*)!⁷⁸

4 Kemālpaşazāde, Imperialist Neopythagorean Historian

Such, then, is the intellectual-ideological context in which Kemālpaşazāde's lettrist episode is to be read; it is not odd or aberrant with respect to his larger scholarly project, a mental lapse, or mere act of mercenary bootlicking, but speaks to its prolific and influential author's subscription to a Neopythagorean cosmology wherein occult science is simply that—*science*.⁷⁹ Thus his deploy-

76 See Taşköprizāde Aḥmed, *al-Shaqā'iq al-nu'māniyya fī 'ulamā' al-dawla al-Uthmāniyya*, ed. Sayyid Muḥammad Ṭabāṭabā'ī Bihbahānī (Tehran: Kitābkhāna, Mūza u Markaz-i Asnād, Majlis-i Shūrā-yi Islāmī, 1389sh/2010): 161–162, no. 137. Cf. Kemālpaşazāde's entry in this work at 331–333, no. 307.

77 Cf. 'Alī b. Muḥammad al-Lakhmī al-Ishbīlī al-Maghribī al-Dimashqī's (d. after 1517) panegyric introduction to his *al-Durr al-muṣān fī sirāt al-muẓaffar Salīm Khān* (“The Preserved Pearl: On the Career of the Victorious King Selīm”), wherein the Sevillan Maliki jurist, in a bid for Ottoman patronage, similarly deploys lettrist and oneiromantic arguments to valorize Selim's conquest of Egypt (Stephen Conermann, “Ibn Ṭūlūn (d. 955/1548), Life and Works,” in Conermann, *Mamlukica: Studies on the History and Society of the Mamluk Period* (Bonn: Bonn University Press, 2013), 213–236: 225–228).

78 This letter is studied and translated in Şen and Melvin-Koushki, “Divining Chaldiran.”

79 On the standard Arabo-Persian classification of the occult sciences as natural and mathematical sciences—and their progressive mathematicalization in post-Mongol Persianate scholarship in tandem with the Neopythagorean renaissance here in view—see Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One.”

ment of the same in his seminal *Annals of the Ottoman House*; thus the astrology stance evinced by his collected fatwas;⁸⁰ thus his authorship of an important plague treatise featuring letter-magical defenses and remedies,⁸¹ as well as a short tract on the divine names;⁸² thus his (probable) authorship of a work on talismans and astral-lettrist magic;⁸³ and thus his commitment to Ibn ‘Arabī, father of early modern lettrist theory, both philosophically and imperially.

This is not to suggest that Kemālpāşazāde be approached as primarily an occultist: the bulk of his scholarly production was in fields unrelated or adjacent, particularly jurisprudence, theology, and Arabic linguistics (for all that the last also suggests a lettrist sensibility). The same principle applies to those of his colleagues who too made forays into one or more of the occult sciences as a matter of course, such as Müfti Aḥmed Paşa or Kemālpāşazāde’s own teacher Mollā Lütḫī—a student of famed Timurid-Ottoman astronomer ‘Alī Qūshchī (d. 879/1474) in the mathematical sciences—who wrote two treatises on Neopythagorean geometry and the letters of the Arabic alphabet, respectively, and who, as noted, was responsible for first applying the Sūrat al-Rūm prophecy to the 1473 Ottoman-Aqqayunlu battle at Otlukbeli.⁸⁴ (Significantly,

80 Şen, “Practicing Astral Magic,” 86.

81 Nühket Varlık, *Plague and Empire in the Early Modern Mediterranean World: The Ottoman Experience, 1347–1600* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015), 233. Specifically, Kemālpāşazāde’s *Risāla fi l-Ṭā’ūn* has two chapters, the first on using quranic verses and divine names to ward off plague, the second on using animals, plants, and minerals for the same purpose (Süleymaniye, MS Aşir Efendi 430/36, fols. 159^b–160^a).

82 *Risāla fi Tahqīq tawqīfiyyāt asmā’ Allāh ta’ālā*; see Nihal Atsız, “Kemalpaşaoğlu’nun Eserleri II,” *Şarkiyat Mecmuası* 7 (1972): 83–135, esp. 89–90, no. 108; Brockelmann, *GALS*, 2:670, no. 2.76.

83 Şen, “Practicing Astral Magic.”

84 See n. 69 above. An edition and French translation of the first work, *Risālat Taḍḍīf al-madhbaḥ* (“On the Doubling of the Altar/Cube”), was published as *La duplication de l’autel (Platon et le problème de Delos)*, ed. Şerefettin Yaltkaya, trans. and introduced Abdülhak Adnan and Henry Corbin (Paris: de Boccard, 1940). As the latter note (6, 25), this treatise indique un moment de la longue carrière parcourue par les motifs platoniciens, ou plutôt des tous les motifs dont Platon était considéré comme le prophète, combinés avec l’arithmologie néo-pythagoricienne, dans le monde culturel de langue arabe, lequel recueillit l’héritage des savants grecs [O]n notera essentiellement le rôle central reconnu à Pythagore ..., condisciple des élèves de Salomon et à qui est attribuée finalement la dignité de prophète.

That Bāyezid II’s library included a copy of this Neopythagorean-occultist treatise is thus telling indeed; for the list of titles in ‘Aṭṭī’s (d. 1541) 1502 Ottoman palace-library catalog (Hungarian National Library, MS Török fol. 59), recording some 7,200 titles in 5,700 volumes, see *Treasures of Knowledge: An Inventory of the Ottoman Palace Library (1502/3–1503/4)*, ed. Gülrü Necipoğlu, Cemal Kafadar, and Cornell H. Fleischer, 2 vols. (Leiden: Brill,

the first treatise, relying on al-Biṣṭāmī and al-Būnī, presents talismanic magic squares and divine names magic as having indispensable medical, architectural, and imperial applications.⁸⁵) This pattern is common to early modern Persianate—and early modern Western—scholarly culture as a whole; while only a minority (some two to fifteen percent) of scholars achieved fame as professional occultists, few indeed were the luminaries who did not write at least a few tracts in the field of occultism or pepper their more vaunted works with occult-scientific references.⁸⁶ But to ignore such works and passages as peripheral to their authors' "true" concerns is to retroject modern materialist-scientific cosmology onto the decidedly nonmaterialist, panpsychist cosmology of our early modern actors—and hence to wreak vivisectionist colonialist violence on and obliterate precisely such categories as *Neopythagorean historiography*, without which post-Mongol Islamicate imperialism in general and early Ottoman imperialism in particular cannot be fully understood.⁸⁷

2019). As for Mollā Lūṭfi's short treatise on the letters, a copy is preserved as MS Leiden 235 (Brockelmann, *GAL*, 2/235, no. 5.9). On Qūshchī as a member of Ibn Turka's scholarly network and fellow Neopythagoreanizer, see Melvin-Koushki, "Powers of One."

85 Mollā Lūṭfi, *La duplication*, 16–23.

86 Melvin-Koushki and Pickett, "Mobilizing Magic," 263–264. The mainstream status of occultism in early tenth/sixteenth-century Ottoman scholarly circles in particular is exemplified by Taşköprizāde's *Miftāḥ al-sa'āda wa-miṣbāḥ al-siyāda* ("Key to Felicity and Lamp to Mastery"), completed in 1541, a culmination of the Mamluk-Ottoman Arabic encyclopedic tradition and primary model for subsequent Ottoman encyclopedias, including most prominently the *Kashf al-ẓunūn 'an asāmī l-kutub wa-l-funūn* ("Removing Uncertainty as to the Titles of Books and Disciplines") of Ḥājī Khalifa (d. 1657); it mounts an especially robust defense of the occult sciences as a subset of the natural sciences on the one hand and the quranic sciences on the other. Crucially, Taşköprizāde here imports Ibn Turka's signature *tashkik al-ḥarf* scheme to epistemologically structure his encyclopedia as a whole. Melvin-Koushki, "Powers of One," 173–179, and "Of Islamic Grammatology," 89–91. The same lettrist commitment is on full display in his seminal plague treatise, on which see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, "Taşköprizāde on the (Occult) Science of Plague Prevention and Cure," *Nazarīyat* 16, no. 2 (2020), forthcoming.

87 The eclecticism with which such occultist-Neopythagorean content is often deployed by scholars of the period must, however, be acknowledged (my thanks to Cornell Fleischer and Christopher Markiewicz for this observation). This is, nevertheless, evidence precisely for the *routinization* and *naturalization* of Neopythagorean cosmology in the early modern period—a process similarly enshrined in the Arabo-Persianate burgeoning of what may be called "*mu'ammā* (riddle) culture," itself a form of naturalized lettrist Neopythagoreanism, which testifies to a broader social consciousness that the world is de- and reconstructably *semantic* (Melvin-Koushki, "Of Islamic Grammatology," 78–79). Equally importantly, the scholarly architects of this consciousness (and indeed the built environment by extension: cf. the Taj Mahal) were often explicit about their panpsychism; the same cosmology, from Pythagoras to the present, has historically driven Western occult-

Let us therefore cease feting the narrowly materialist-dualist sociology of Ibn Khaldūn, that patron saint of European colonialism: for it was expressly developed to destroy his Timurid rival Yazdī's new occult-monist science of history, in which aim it failed utterly for four centuries. If our historiography of Western early modernity is not similarly to fail, we must take more seriously the Neopythagorean-occultist cosmology that, radiating from Cairo, swept the Persianate world during the ninth/fifteenth century and provided theoretical justification for and materially furthered the greatest empires and scientific-scholarly endeavors of the tenth/sixteenth and eleventh/seventeenth. This includes, in the first place, the watershed *mathematical turn* in Arabic astronomy, as pursued by the members of the Timurid sultan-scientist Ulugh Beg's (r. 811–853/1409–1449) Samarkand Observatory in the early ninth/fifteenth century, celebrated by historians of science as possible precedent for the Copernican revolution in Latinate Europe (and hence the equally explicitly Neopythagorean-occultist cosmologizing of Kepler and Newton), as well as the florescence of Safavid antiquarian-perennialist philosophy in the tenth/sixteenth and eleventh/seventeenth.⁸⁸ (Again, that Kemālpaşazāde was the student of Qūshchī's student Mollā Lūṭfī is highly suggestive.) For ideas and ideologies have material consequences: they possess the ability to reshape landscapes just as surely as military technologies or tax regimes, as plague or climate change. Far from being embarrassingly irrational but minor gushings that may be safely ignored by the modern historian, then, it is precisely ephemeral documents like Kemālpaşazāde's lettrist call for the conquest of Cairo that provide us directest access to the realtime, material effects of that cosmology at a crucial moment in Ottoman, Islamicate, and Western history; we must begin to prize them as such.

5 Conclusion

Both militarily and magically, Selīm's short but watershed reign, quintessentially early modern in its expansionism and experimentalism, was a period of creative flux; it represents a pivotal moment in the development of Ottoman millenarian, apocalyptic, and especially occult-scientific imperialist discourse, already incipient under his father, Bāyezīd, and fully articulated by his son

scientific theory and practice. It should therefore not need saying, but shockingly does, that the occult sciences cannot be read through a strictly materialist or monocultural lens without doing them considerable epistemic violence.

88 See Melvin-Koushki, "Powers of One"; Melvin-Koushki, "World as (Arabic) Text."

Süleymān. It is then, moreover, that a productive political-scientific tension between astrology and lettrism first emerged. Where Bāyezīd had institutionalized astrology to a degree unprecedented and unparalleled in the Islamo-Christianate West, the Ottoman court under Selīm and Süleymān would appear to have somewhat de-emphasized the science of the stars in favor of the science of the letters, whereby even astronomical-astrological data were increasingly analyzed in lettrist terms, and Ottoman imperialism definitively *Ibn ‘Arabianized* in a Biṣṭāmian mode.⁸⁹ Such texts as Idrīs Bidlīsī’s chronicle, Müfti Aḥmed Paşa’s *tehnīyetnāme*, and Kemālpaşazāde’s lettrist treatise thus record, I suggest, the genesis of this signal Ottoman ideological shift. And that shift was precipitated by Selīm’s conquest of Cairo—the urban alembic where, just over a century prior, Ibn ‘Arabian-Būnian lettrism had been reformulated as a universal, *imperial* science by peripatetic Timurid-Ottoman scholars in service to an ambitiously experimental Mamluk sovereign, Barqūq, then carried by the same scholars back east and north and there considerably elaborated, only to return with Selīm to its birthplace fully weaponized.

That Kemālpaşazāde seems to have chosen an exclusively *lettrist* argument to urge his royal patron to take Cairo is thus of no little significance. For the ideological and legal stakes were high: in order to sidestep the blatant illegality of invading a fellow Islamic state, our learned Ottoman jurist-historian clearly felt it strategic at this critical juncture to both emulate and challenge the Neopythagorean-occultist historiography developed by his scholarly predecessors or contemporaries al-Biṣṭāmī, Ibn Turka, Yazdī, Davānī, Khunjī, and Bidlīsī, and to expressly honor its Mamluk-Cairene stemming. In other words, the *Ottoman lettrist imperialism* that is such a distinctive feature of the expansive and transformative Süleymānic era is a product of inner-Persianate scholarly circulation and competition between Egypt, Iran, and Anatolia, that golden intellectual-imperial triangle, over the course of the equally transformative ninth/fifteenth century; at the beginning of the tenth/sixteenth, it was consciously developed on a Mamluk-Timurid-Aqqyunlu model and Ottomanized by Bidlīsī, turncoat Aqqyunlu historian, then strategically reprised by influen-

89 Şen, “Astrology in the Service,” 207–210. While astrologers continued as salaried court officials down to the dissolution of the Ottoman Empire in the early fourteenth/twentieth century, their number and salaries decreased under Bāyezīd’s successors. On a similar fusing of astronomy/astrology with lettrism for Mughal imperial purposes—in explicit invocation of the Timurid dual astrological-lettrist platform established by Ibn Turka and Yazdī—see Matthew Melvin-Koushki, “Timurid-Mughal Philosopher-Kings as Sultan-Scientists,” in *Rulers as Authors in the Islamic World: Knowledge, Authority and Legitimacy*, ed. Maribel Fierro, Sonja Brentjes, and Tilman Seidensticker (Leiden: Brill, forthcoming).

tial Ottoman imperial scholar-ideologues like Kemālpaşazāde.⁹⁰ At the same time, the Ottoman prophet al-Bisṭāmī's equally explicit mathematicalization of the science of history within a lettrist framework could not but have provided further impetus.

Nor was that impetus quick to dissipate. The same lettrist framework persisted as a particularly meaty bone of historiographical contention between rival Persianate imperial cultures through at least the early eleventh/seventeenth century, as proved by its adaptation by none other than the great Safavid philosopher Mīr Dāmād (d. 1041/1631), an avowed Ibn Turkian lettrist, who constructed the first specifically Twelver Shi'i philosophy and science of history—thereby occult-scientifically disproving the Ottoman-Bisṭāmian eschatological claims of the previous century.⁹¹ Unsurprisingly, Mughal imperial ideology too appears to have remained no less lettrist during the same period.⁹²

Kemālpaşazāde's brief, putative lettrist treatise for Selim thus performs, with impressive efficiency, its author's mastery of this emergent Mamluk-Timurid-Aqquyunlu-Ottoman (and then Safavid-Mughal) common scholarly and historiographical culture. At the same time, it is no less representative of intellectual and cultural developments peculiar to the Mediterranean zone as an integral unit, and especially Iberia and the Maghrib: for it is there that lettrism-kabbalah was first sanctified during the sixth/twelfth and seventh/thirteenth centuries,⁹³ whence it swept east along both shores and helped drive both the renaissance of occult-scientific Neopythagoreanism and the millenarian scientific-imperial expansionism that define mathematizing and globalizing Western early modernity.

In this hybridized Persianate-Mediterranean context, in sum, Selīm the Grim too must therefore be read as an early modern Western imperial experimentalist pursuing—wildly successfully, as it turned out—a new brand of millennial, monist-universalist sovereignty predicated on an occult-scientific understanding, a *deep reading*, of history and the cosmos.

90 Cf. Kemālpaşazāde's championing of Persian as preeminent language of scholarship and spirituality, second only to Arabic, in his *Risāla fī Faḍīlat al-lisān al-fārisī 'alā l-alsina siwā l-lisān al-'arabī* (in *Rasā'il Ibn Kamāl*, 2 vols. (Istanbul: Dār al-Khilāfa al-'Ilmiyya, 1316/1898), 2:210–216).

91 Melvin-Koushki, "World as (Arabic) Text."

92 Melvin-Koushki, "Timurid-Mughal Philosopher-Kings."

93 The "age of esotericism and its disclosure," as Moshe Halbertal has termed this pivotal moment in Western history (*Concealment and Revelation: Esotericism in Jewish Thought and Its Philosophical Implications*, trans. Jackie Feldman (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2007), 5); on the pan-Mediterranean relevance of this periodization, see Noah Gardiner, "Stars and Saints: The Esotericist Astrology of the Sufi Occultist Aḥmad al-Būnī," *Magic, Ritual, and Witchcraft* 12, no. 1 (2017): 39–65, esp. 63–65.

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